



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

MIN 706 (M+F) New IMO voluntary guidelines

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Summary

This Marine Information Note is to highlight that the International Maritime Organization (IMO) has recently adopted voluntary guidelines relating to biofouling and underwater radiated noise.

1. The 2023 Biofouling Guidelines

1.1 The Guidelines for the control and management of ships' biofouling to minimize the transfer of invasive aquatic species (Biofouling Guidelines) are intended to provide a globally consistent approach to the management of biofouling. The Biofouling Guidelines represent a step towards reducing the transfer of invasive aquatic species by ships.

1.2 The guidelines were adopted by the Marine Environment Protection Committee at its eightieth session and replace the 2011 Biofouling Guidelines.

1.3 The 2023 Biofouling Guidelines can be found in resolution MEPC.378(80) at www.imo.org (<http://www.imo.org>) and are available [here](https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MEPCDocuments/MEPC.378(80).pdf) ([https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MEPCDocuments/MEPC.378\(80\).pdf](https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MEPCDocuments/MEPC.378(80).pdf)).

1.4 Ships are encouraged to use the guidelines in order minimize the risk of invasive species and provide feedback on their use where possible. Management practices such as those contained in the guidelines can also improve a ship's hydrodynamic performance which can improve fuel consumption and air emissions.

1.5 Feedback can be emailed to environment@mcga.gov.uk and will be used to inform discussions at the IMO when the guidelines are next revised.

1.6 We are looking to compile a list of interested parties that would be willing to discuss their experience of these guidelines. If you are interested, please email environment@mcga.gov.uk.

2. The 2023 Underwater Radiated Noise Guidelines

2.1 The draft guidelines recognize that commercial shipping is one of the main contributors to underwater radiated noise (URN) which has adverse effects on critical life functions for a wide range of marine life, including marine mammals, fish and invertebrate species, upon which many coastal Indigenous communities depend for their food, livelihoods and cultures. The draft revised guidelines provide an overview of approaches applicable to designers, shipbuilders and ship operators to reduce the underwater radiated noise of any given ship. They are intended to assist relevant stakeholders in establishing mechanisms and programmes through which noise reduction efforts can be realized.

2.2 The draft guidelines include updated technical knowledge, including reference to international measurement standards, recommendations and classification society rules. They also provide sample templates to assist shipowners with the development of an underwater radiated noise management plan.

2.3 The guidelines were approved by the Marine Environment Protection Committee at its eightieth session and replace the 2014 Underwater Noise Guidelines.

2.4 The 2023 Underwater Radiated Noise Guidelines can be found in circular MEPC.1/Circ.906 and are available at www.imo.org (<http://www.imo.org>) [here](https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/Documents/MEPC.1-Circ.906%20-%20Revised%20Guidelines%20For%20The%20Reduction%20Of%20Underwater%20Radiated%20NoiseFrom%20Shipping%20To%20Address...%20(Secretariat).pdf) ([https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/Documents/MEPC.1-Circ.906%20-%20Revised%20Guidelines%20For%20The%20Reduction%20Of%20Underwater%20Radiated%20NoiseFrom%20Shipping%20To%20Address...%20\(Secretariat\).pdf](https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/Documents/MEPC.1-Circ.906%20-%20Revised%20Guidelines%20For%20The%20Reduction%20Of%20Underwater%20Radiated%20NoiseFrom%20Shipping%20To%20Address...%20(Secretariat).pdf)).

2.5 Ships are encouraged to use the guidelines in order to minimize the effects of underwater radiated noise and provide feedback on their use, where possible.

2.6 Feedback can be emailed to environment@mcga.gov.uk and will be used to inform discussions at the IMO when the guidelines are next revised.

2.7 We are looking to compile a list of interested parties that would be willing to discuss their experience of these guidelines. If you are interested, please email environment@mcga.gov.uk.

More information

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